RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

The Dead Will Rise: Principle 13

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 18

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 13 (*Techiyat HaMetim*), with the Rambam's ***Ma'amar Techiyat HaMetim***, Mishneh Torah, the Ra'avad, and the other Rishonim

Shiur: Part 18 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 24 February 2026 (the week before Purim)

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

The shiur was dedicated לעילוי נשמת יצחק דניאל בן משה זאב. "All the Torah we learn, and all the Torah disseminated through the technology being used: may it be for the elevation of his soul. מן השמים תנוחמו."

Schedule

- **Next week is Purim: no shiur.**
- **In two weeks: one final shiur** on **the Rambam's concluding paragraph**: what follows if one denies any of the principles, and how that applies today. **Then the Moreh.**

Part 1: The Text: Two Words

היסוד השלשה עשר: תחיית המתים. וכבר בארנוה.

The thirteenth principle: the resurrection of the dead. We have already explained it. "**Full stop. That's the end.**"

"Already explained": earlier in the Introduction (we learnt it **around November**, before the winter break), where, discussing **Olam HaBa**, the Rambam also covers **Mashiach, Gan Eden, Gehinnom and *Techiyat HaMetim***:

> **ותחיית המתים יסוד מיסודות תורת משה רבנו עליו השלום, ואין דת ולא דבקות בדת היהודית למי שלא יאמין זה. אבל היא לצדיקים...**

Resurrection is a foundation of Moshe's Torah: **no part in the Jewish religion** for one who doesn't believe it. **But it's for the righteous.**

ודע כי האדם יש לו למות בהכרח, ויפרד וישוב למה שהורכב ממנו.

Know that a person must die, separating and returning to what he was composed of.

"**Perhaps the most illuminating sentence.** We're made **from the dust**. **The righteous will rise again in their bodies, and then die again**, and then go to **Olam HaBa**, which for the Rambam is **purely spiritual**."

Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal

	Text
Ani Ma'amin	**שתהיה תחיית המתים בעת שיעלה רצון מאת הבורא, יתברך שמו ויתעלה זכרו לעד ולנצח נצחים**
Yigdal	**מתים יחיה אל ברוב חסדו, ברוך עדי עד שם תהלתו**

"**Basically the same; nothing new.**"

Part 2: The Sources

In Chazal and the liturgy, everywhere: the **second *berachah* of the Amidah**, three times a day. **In the Torah, nothing explicit**, though many hints; **in Nevi'im and Ketuvim, explicit**.

Source	Verse	Reading
Ha'azinu (Devarim 32:39)	**ראו עתה כי אני אני הוא ואין אלהים עמדי, אני אמית ואחיה, מחצתי ואני ארפא**	**"I strike and I heal" is the same person**, so **"I kill and I bring to life"** is too. "**The order seems wrong: it should be *I give life and I kill***." (**Rav Saadia** brings this)
Yeshayahu 26:19	**יחיו מתיך נבלתי יקומון, הקיצו ורננו שכני עפר**	**Your dead will live; dwellers in the dust, awake and sing**
Daniel 12:2	**ורבים מישני אדמת עפר יקיצו, אלה לחיי עולם**	**Many who sleep in the dust will awake**, some to **everlasting life**

Not reincarnation

Resurrection = **the dead come alive again**. **Not *gilgul***, **a soul returning in a new body**: "**clearly the Rambam didn't believe in it**; it **doesn't fit anywhere in his framework** and he **never discusses it**. **Nor did Rav Saadia. There's no traditional source for it.**" A different topic.

Part 3: Why So Brief?

"**The question that bothered many since medieval times.**"

Work	What the Rambam says about resurrection
Commentary on the Mishnah (this)	**Two words**: *"already explained"*
Mishneh Torah	Focuses on **Olam HaBa** and **the immortal soul**. **One mention**, in Hilchot Teshuvah 3: no portion for **הכופרים בתחיית המתים ובביאת הגואל**
Moreh Nevuchim	**Nowhere discussed philosophically**; one **incidental** reference in another context

In his lifetime the Rambam was accused of not believing in physical resurrection.

The Ra'avad

The Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 8:2): העולם הבא אין בו גוף וגויה... אין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה... תשמיש המטה, אלא צדיקים יושבין ועטרותיהן בראשיהן ונהנין מזיו השכינה. No body, no eating or drinking: the righteous sit with crowns on their heads, enjoying the radiance of the Shechinah.

The Ra'avad (R. Avraham ben David, "**his harshest critic**"): **אמר אברהם: דברי האיש הזה בעיני קרובים למי שאומר אין תחיית המתים לגופות אלא לנשמות בלבד.**

"This man's words seem to me close to one who says resurrection is for souls only, not bodies." **בחיי ראשי, לא היה זה דעת חכמים**: Chazal say the righteous **rise in their clothes**; they **rise with their blemishes** (a broken leg, a broken hip) **and are then healed**. **וכל אלה מוכיחים כי בגויותיהם עומדים בחיים**.

"**That's essentially the question: did the Rambam believe in a physical resurrection? What *is* the thirteenth principle?**" "**If we didn't have his letter, people would have a point.**"

Part 4: *Ma'amar Techiyat HaMetim*

"Last year we did a series on the Rambam's letters, martyrdom and others. The major one we didn't do was the letter on resurrection."

Why he wrote it

- **The Mishneh Torah had spread** to many lands. **A certain *chacham*** ("**from Syria, I think**") cited it to **deny physical resurrection**: **only the soul is immortal**.
- At first he **ignored it**: "**people always misunderstand whatever you write**."
- Then in **1189** a letter **from Yemen**: **many were denying physical resurrection** because he'd written so little. **So he wrote the essay.**

"However clear you are, people twist your words"

Ask any Jew: **God is one. שמע ישראל ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד.**

The Christians of his day: **three names, *Hashem, Elokeinu, Hashem***: **Father, Son and Holy Ghost**; ***echad***: **the Trinity is one**.

"**A verse so clear, so explicit, so unambiguous**, and they made **the unity of God** into **the Trinity**. **What do you want me to do** if people misunderstand **me**?"

His defence

"**It's not true. I wrote it in my Commentary: it's one of the Thirteen Principles.** I was **brief**" (**he concedes it**). **There will be a physical resurrection.**

Why so terse?
A. Brevity is my style.
B. There's little to say: it **can't be defended by philosophical investigation**; **it's a matter of belief**.
C. It's not the main thing. The main thing is Olam HaBa: נהנין מזיו השכינה. "**I don't want people bogged down in resurrection and thinking that's all.**"

How it fits

If Olam HaBa is purely spiritual, what is a physical resurrection for?

The dead rise, live a while, die again, and then begin Olam HaBa: "the real McCoy, the final destination."

The Rambam's picture, assembled

Stage	
1	The righteous die and **begin their Olam HaBa**
2	**Around the time of Mashiach** (before or after), **here on earth**, **the dead come alive physically**
3	They **live some time** ("we don't know how long")
4	They **die again and return to the dust**
5	**Olam HaBa**: **pure spiritual bliss**, nothing physical

"**I don't know of any other Rishon who takes this approach.** I think **he's unique**."

In academia, some argue **the letter wasn't his real view** but **written for the masses**. "**It's not for me to put a view on that. He wrote it, and we take his words at face value.**"

Part 5: Hints of Another Reading

1. Professor Marc Shapiro: the order in Hilchot Teshuvah 3

Halachah	Principles
3:7	**1–5**
3:8	**6–9**, and **10**
3:6	**הכופרים בתחיית המתים ובביאת הגואל**: **12 13** then
—	**11 missing**

"**Two questions:** where's **11**? (Rav Shilat: it's **a consequence of 10**.) And **why 13 before 12?** Everywhere else **Mashiach comes first**."

Shapiro's suggestion: in Mishneh Torah "***Techiyat HaMetim*" alludes to a spiritual resurrection: the immortality of the soul**, i.e. **Principle 11 (Olam HaBa)**. **That answers both**: **11 is there**, and **the order is 11, 12**. "**Interesting. The problem: he does have Principle 13.**"

2. The cemetery blessing (the *Keter Shem Tov*)

Rav Gaguin, **Chacham of the Spanish and Portuguese** in the early 1900s, recorded their customs **in seven volumes**.

	Text
Gemara (Berachot 58b)	**ברוך... אשר יצר אתכם בדין, וזן אתכם בדין, וכלכל אתכם בדין, והמית אתכם בדין, ויודע מספר כולכם, והוא עתיד להחיותכם ולקיימכם... ברוך אתה ה׳ מחיה המתים**
The Rambam (Hilchot Berachot 10:11)	**והמית אתכם בדין, ועתיד להקימכם בדין לחיי העולם הבא**...

"**Only the Rambam adds *lechayei Olam HaBa*.** There are **many texts** in the Geonim and Rishonim (**I'm looking into this now: I was asked about the text in a certain cemetery**), and **no one else brings in Olam HaBa**."

But in his letter, resurrection has nothing to do with Olam HaBa: you come **out** of it, live, die, and go back. **Here he seems to equate them.**

The Keter Shem Tov ends: והמשכיל יבין. "**Code words.** When a *chacham* wants to convey something he's **uncomfortable saying outright** (**Ibn Ezra** uses it a lot; ***vehamaskil yidom***: if you're wise, keep quiet). **His book isn't theological; he rarely writes it. I think he was hinting at this.**"

3. Chief Rabbi Hertz

The Hertz Siddur (used in **most United Synagogues**), **p. 255**: "**Maimonides makes the doctrine of the resurrection of the dead identical with that of the immortality of the soul, and explains the Talmudic sayings to the contrary as figurative language.**"

"**Did Hertz not know of the letter? Of course he knew.**"

"Why am I telling you this?"

"**Perhaps I should keep quiet: *vehamaskil yavin*.** I'll tell you why. **Let me be very clear: the overwhelming understanding of the Rambam is that the thirteenth principle is belief in a physical resurrection.**"

The difficulties	The ruling
Philosophically, how resurrection fits his eschatology **is very difficult**	**He writes very clearly that he believes**, so ***al panav*, our duty is to believe in a physical resurrection.** "**Sometimes we accept what we can't understand.**"
His brevity everywhere, and **the hints**	

"**Someone who says *I find physical resurrection difficult; I understand the thirteenth principle as Olam HaBa, spiritual identity: I wouldn't call him a kofer. Deny any of the principles and you are a kofer***, with **many sanctions** (our final shiur). **But this, I personally wouldn't**, given everything we've seen."

Part 6: The Other Views

	The Rambam	The Ramban (with R. Meir HaLevi / the Ramah; articulated by the Ramchal and the Kabbalah)	Rav Saadia Gaon (and other Rishonim)
Order	Resurrection **in this world**, then **death**, then **Olam HaBa**	Mashiach (12) → death → **the world ends → resurrection ushers in Olam HaBa**	**Two resurrections**
Olam HaBa is…	**Souls only**	**Body and soul together**	
The body	Returns to dust	**Our own bodies**, "**you'll see your flesh**," but **refined and elevated**	
After		**Live forever**	**1st**, at **Mashiach's** time, **for the righteous of Israel**; **2nd**, after the world ends, **for all with a portion in Olam HaBa, including non-Jews**
Strength		"**Philosophically very cogent**," though **a physical Olam HaBa** is **a strong question** for the Rambam	(We learnt it in ***Emunot veDe'ot***)

Albo: "When they come alive, we'll know"

Sefer Halkkarim IV:35: הדבר הזה חלקו בו גדולי האחרונים.

- **The Rambam "and many sages with him"**: **the dead, once revived, will use all their physical senses as is normal, then die and return to dust.**

- **R. Meir HaLevi, the Ramah and the Ramban**: they'll live **their natural span**, and **then their bodies will be refined like Eliyahu and Chanoch**, **body and soul**, **enjoying the radiance of the Shechinah**, **sustained forever without food or drink**.

"Strange, but possible." **Which is right? התשובה לכל זה וכיוצא בו היא כמו שהשיב רבי יהושע בן חנניה לאנשי אלכסנדריא: כשיחיו נחכם להם.**

When they come alive, we'll know. "**So much ambiguity: when, how, where it falls in the framework. Don't worry about it. You don't need to know.**"

The takeaway: "**There is a thirteenth principle: belief in a physical resurrection of the dead. When, why, how: different views.** Someone who believes **only in a spiritual resurrection** I wouldn't call a *kofer*, **but one can't go against the Rambam's plain words in his letter**. **Prima facie, it's physical.**"

Part 7: Questions

Robert: *Does the Rambam hold people keep being born after* Techiyat HaMetim*, and so miss it, since it's a once-in-history event?*

"**I'm almost sure the Rambam doesn't discuss it anywhere. Rav Saadia** does: **they'll marry, have children, live long. But if Mashiach came now, you and I wouldn't experience it either**: we're alive. **It's for those who died. I don't see an issue.**"

Will they wake up to strangers*, a hundred or two hundred years on? *As a baby or an old person?

"Rav Saadia happens to say **you'll meet your family**, **but that's not the point**. **Not as a baby: some kind of adult. When it happens, we'll worry about it.**"

Is it like Mashiach, believe but don't calculate?

"**You're right.**" Even **Olam HaBa**, the Rambam says, is like **describing colours to someone blind from birth**: "**how do you explain red and green?**" **But he spends ages on Olam HaBa** because **it's the ultimate**. **Mashiach and *Techiyat HaMetim* are principles of faith, but compared to Olam HaBa, far lower.** "**The Rambam says it about Mashiach, Albo about resurrection, and I think the Rambam would say the same**: **it can't be defended philosophically; it's a belief.**"

Part 8: From What Body?

Rav Saadia is unequivocal: **the actual decomposed parts** of the body are **reconstituted**.

Cremation

"**I once gave a whole shiur on cremation. God forbid: it's absolutely forbidden. The exact source** is **a big discussion: six or seven views**."

One of the most interesting: the *Minchat Elazar* (the Munkatcher Rebbe): **cremating yourself denies resurrection**: *how will you rise from ashes?*

"**My simple thought when I read that: so all the people burnt to ashes in Auschwitz won't be resurrected?**" **Rav Saadia himself**: **nothing is completely destroyed**; **from the smallest atoms left, Hashem can reconstitute the body**.

	Body at resurrection
Rav Saadia	**The original matter**, reconstituted
Chasdai Crescas (*Or Hashem*) and others	**Not necessarily**: Hashem can **fashion a body identical to the one you lived in**

Summary

1. **Principle 13: *Techiyat HaMetim*, "already explained"**: **a foundation of the Torah, for the righteous**, and **"a person must die and return to dust"**.
2. **Sources: אני אמית ואחיה** (Ha'azinu); **Yeshayahu**, **Daniel**. **Not *gilgul***.
3. **The Rambam is terse everywhere**, and **the Ra'avad** read him as **souls only**.

4. ***Ma'amar Techiyat HaMetim*** (after a **1189 letter from Yemen**): **physical resurrection, yes**; brief because of **style**, because **it's belief, not philosophy**, and because **Olam HaBa is the main thing**. **Rise, live, die again, then Olam HaBa**: "**unique among the Rishonim**."
5. **Hints otherwise: Shapiro** (13 before 12, 11 missing); **the cemetery blessing's *lechayei Olam HaBa*** and the ***Keter Shem Tov's* והמשכיל יבין**; **Rabbi Hertz**.
6. **The ruling: *al panav* we believe in a physical resurrection**; one who understands it spiritually **"I wouldn't call a *kofer*"**.
7. **The Ramban:** resurrection **ushers in an embodied Olam HaBa**. **Rav Saadia: two resurrections**. **Albo: כשיחיו נחכם להם.**
8. **Same matter or new? Rav Saadia** vs **Crescas**; **cremation** is forbidden, but **Hashem can raise even the ashes of Auschwitz**.

Coming Up

After Purim (in two weeks): the final shiur of the series: **the Rambam's concluding paragraph**, what follows from **denying any of the Thirteen Principles**, and **how it applies today**. Then **the Moreh Nevuchim**.

"**Wishing everyone a beautiful, happy and enjoyable Purim.**"

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/nFMIR2_7txM · More shiurim: rabbikada.com